reader I

Maravilloso Reading Group

If we build politically by virtue of the vulnerability of our bodies, then we have to recognize the vulnerability of the body as something indisputable.

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El Inicio / The Beginning and selected quotes from Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia

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[...]

p. 123 (Lipovetsky)

Material poverty is lived as a lack of autonomy and a lack of access to one's own projects, as the obsession with survival, as the feeling of failure and social collapse. In consumer societies, precarity intensifies psychological troubles, the conviction that one has failed at life. For those classes of people who are socialized by work and who enjoy a certain social mobility, properly material frustrations tend to diminish. Yet among the underdogs frustrations get worse and lead to the conviction that they are leading a life that is not a life. This is the violence of the civilization of happiness, its new ordeal.

p. 28

The explosion of unrestrained and hyperspecialized violence is evidence of the lack of any (regulable) future, along with the fact that in capitalism's interstices no one has anything to lose, because life is no longer important (which means that the taboo against killing has been entirely undone). Violence continually iterated in the here and now makes it impossible to contemplate the idea of the future in the ways the West has customarily done. The violence demands a reassessment of futurity itself.

Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia

[selected fragments]

p. 83

It is also relevant to ask how extreme violence, gender, death and thanatopolitics have been converted into a new form of fierce and unapologetic capitalism. How have these endriago subjects decided to participate in the world market and how have they empowered themselves in the parallel criminal economy sustained by the formal economy?

p. 77 (Lipovetsky)

Until recently poverty described traditionally stable and identifiable social groups that were able to subsist thanks to local solidarities. This era is over: the repudiated populations of post-industrial society no longer constitute, properly speaking, a fixed social class. The landscape of hypermodern social exclusion is an incoherent nebula of particular situations and social routes. In this pluridimensional constellation there is no class-consciousness, group solidarity, or sense of common destiny, only clusters of very different personal stories and trajectories. Victims of social invalidation and of individual difficulties and situations, the new unaffiliated emerge in society at once brutally unequal and hyper-individualist—a society, in other words, that has been liberated from the sociocultural framework of traditional class structures.

Esto es Tijuana

The fury of clouds that is the Pacific Ocean.

A dismembered torso strewn across the highway at rush hour. Cigarettes lit in rapid succession. The neon lights of the red-light district, microscopic universes. Arboreal metastasis.

Narcos. Machismo. Silicone Land. Whore-Barbie's Factory. High caliber weapons laughing, cackling. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Leaving and staying at the same time. Finding another way to say that everything is an eternal return. Irrevocable trajectories and irrevocable women. Violence, tedium and the everyday grind: overdrawn on all accounts. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The word *Bienvenidos* laughing in my face. The word *Bienvenidos* meaning every entrance is an exit. Silence stabs. The desert boils. Migrant screams ring out. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Donkey-zebras imitating nostalgia. Shiny new cars. Enraged taxis. The head repeats an atrocious mantra, "open (yourself) up on the inside." Get into the game. See the Fire. Escape constantly and once and for all bet on winning. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Where the questions where, when and why might not exist, the same as the word "never." Where half of the half does not compute. Where *Interminably* is the same as *Now.*

City of *over and over again.* Where the truth is never known. Where all words—including the word incest—portend multiple histories. Where *mi casa es su casa.* Where *su casa no es mi casa.* Where yes, actually, *su casa es mi caza*: I'm on a hunt and your house is my prey. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La línea never frees itself from the metallic serpent on either side.

A *frontera*-woman looks like death and walks with one hand on her revolver. The syringe-man unsuccessfully attempts to fly along the middle of the metal serpent. The transparent and the true. The piercing.

The first and the third world. The border. El bordo. Hell. The other part of the other side. The other side of the other side. The *This* side of the *Other* side. The happy world of disenchantment. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The limit. The perimeter. The edge of the world. He/she/they/what is dragged behind. The shore that licks white, middle-class, civilized culture and brings it to its end. The time bomb that detonates us. San Diego's garage.

The divided sea laughing raucously *entre las olas. Entre Las Solas.* In the waves and in all the women on their own. The grayness. The paradox. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The *copyright* of the end. *Cartel-right.* Gore capitalism. *Hotels, attractions, nightlife, restaurants, weather and border crossing...*

A blind search for combinatorics. Two million possibilities. *Crunchy, spicy and totally addictive-fabulous blends. Depictions of sodomy, bestiality, alternative sexual practices, racial and ethnic stereotypes. This is Tijuana.*

Everything that enters or leaves the city comes from two parts. Everything here leaves in two or more parts. *You can have whatever you can buy.* City of businesses. Virgin girls *for sale.* Affordable prices for foreigners. Luis Donaldo Colosio Acribillado (a.k.a Bullet-Riddled). Música de banda. Morgue. Techno. NAFTA. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La Tía Juana, Tiguana, Tiuana, Teguana, Tiwana, Tijuan, Ticuan, TJ, Tijuas: you can call her whatever you want because Tijuana—like every other word—means nothing and means: "beside the sea."

Esto es *Queerland.* "Aquí empieza la patria / The homeland begins here."

Esto es Tijuana.

At the brink of el bordo, I become blade.

Tijuana is affectionate. Unfathomable. Full of possibilities.

To be in love with a psychopath and to say so with a smile.

You should leave now. This is Tijuana.

[from] Things We Lost in the Fire by Mariana Enríquez

The cop came in with his head high and proud, his wrists free of cuffs, wearing the ironic smile she knew so well; he oozed impunity and contempt. She'd seen many like him. She had managed to convict far too few.

"Have a seat, Officer," she told him.

The district attorney's office was on the first floor and her window looked out onto nothing, just a hollow between buildings. She'd been asking for a change in office and jurisdiction for a long time. She hated the darkness of that hundred-year-old building, and hated even more that her cases came from the impoverished slums on the city's south side, cases where crime was always mixed with hardship.

The cop sat down, and she reluctantly asked her secretary to bring two cups of coffee.

"You know why you're here. You also know you are under no obligation to tell me anything. Why didn't you bring your lawyer?"

"I know how to defend myself. And anyway, I'm innocent."

The district attorney sighed and toyed with her ring. How many times had she witnessed this exact scene? How many times had a cop like this one denied, to her face and against all evidence, that he had murdered a poor teenager? Because that was what the cops did in the southern slums, much more than protect people: they killed teenagers, sometimes out of cruelty, other times because the kids refused to "work" for them—to steal for them or sell the drugs the police seized. Or for betraying them. The reasons for killing poor kids were many and despicable.

"Officer, we have your voice on tape. Would you like to hear the recording?"

"I don't say anything on that tape."

"You don't say anything. Let's have a listen, then."

She had the audio file on her computer, and she opened it. The cop's voice came through the speakers: "Problem solved. They learned to swim."

The cop snorted. "What does that prove?" he asked.

"By the time stamp as well as your words, it proves that you at least knew that two young men had been thrown into the Ricachuelo."

Pinat had been investigating the case for two months. After bribing police to talk, after threats and afternoons of rage brought on by the incompetence of the judge and the DAs who'd come before her, she had put together a version of events on which the few final and formally obtained statements agreed: Emanuel López and Yamil Corvalán, both fifteen, had gone dancing in Constitución and were returning home to Villa Moreno, a slum on the banks of the Riachuelo. They went on foot because they didn't have money for the bus. They were intercepted by two cops from the thirty-fourth precinct who accused them of trying to rob a kiosk; Yamil had a knife on him, but that attempted robbery was never confirmed, since there was no police report. The cops were drunk. They beat the teens almost unconscious on the riverbank. Next, they kicked them up the cement stairs to the lookout on the bridge over the river, then pushed them into the water. "Problem solved, they learned to swim," were the words that Officer Cuesta, the accused man who was now in her office, had said over the official radio. The idiot hadn't had the conversation erased; all her years as DA had also accustomed her to that, to the impossible combination of brutality and stupidity she encountered in the cops she dealt with.

Yamil Corvalán's body washed up a kilometer down from the bridge. At that point the Riachuelo has almost no current; it is calm and dead, with its oil and plastic scraps and heavy chemicals, the city's great garbage can. The autopsy established that the boy had tried to swim through the black grease. He had drowned when his arms couldn't move anymore. The police had tried for months to sustain the fiction that the teenager's death was accidental, but a woman had heard his screams that night: "Please, please! Help! They pushed me in! I'm drowning!" the boy shouted. The woman hadn't tried to help him. She knew it was impossible to get him out of the water except with a boat, and she didn't have a boat. None of the neighbors did.

Emanuel's body hadn't surfaced. But his parents confirmed he had gone out with Yamil that night. And his running shoes had washed ashore, unmistakable because they were an expensive, imported brand. He'd surely stolen them, and he'd worn them that night to impress the girls at the dance club. His mother had recognized them immediately. She also said that Officers Cuesta and Suárez had been harassing her son, though she didn't know why. The DA had questioned her in that very office the week the teenagers had disappeared. The woman had cried; she'd cried and said that her son was a good boy although yes, sometimes he stole and every once in a while he did drugs, but that was because his father had left them and they were very poor and the boy wanted things, shoes and an iPhone and all the stuff he saw on TV. And he didn't deserve to die like that, drowned because some cops wanted to laugh at him, to laugh while he tried to swim in the polluted water.

No, of course he didn't deserve it, she'd told the woman.

"Ma'am, I did not throw anyone in the river." The cop leaned back in his chair. "And that's all I'm saying."

"As you wish. This was your chance to make a deal that could, maybe, lessen your sentence. We need to know where that body is, and if you give us that information, who knows, maybe you could go to a smaller jail or to the evangelist cell

block. You know the evangelists would go easier on you."

The cop laughed. He was laughing at her, and he was laughing at the dead boys.

"You think they're gonna give me much time? For this?"

"I'm going to try to have you locked up for good."

The DA was about to lose her cool. She squeezed her hands into fists. She looked into the cop's eyes for a moment, and then he said very clearly, in a different, more serious voice, without a trace of irony:

"If only that whole slum would go up in flames. Or every last one of those people would drown. You don't know what goes on there. You. You have no idea."

SHE DID HAVE SOME IDEA. Marina Pinat had been DA for eight years. She'd visited the Villa Moreno slum several times even though it wasn't required by her job—she could investigate from her desk like all her colleagues did, but she preferred to meet the people she read about in the files. Just months before, her investigation had helped a group of families win a case against a nearby tannery that had been dumping chromium and other toxic waste into the water for decades. It had been an extensive and complex civil suit she'd spent years working on. There were families who lived by the water and drank it, and though the mothers boiled it to try to get the poison out, their children got sick, consumed by cancer in three months, with horrible skin eruptions that ate away at their legs and arms. And some of them had been born with deformities. Extra arms (sometimes up to four), noses wide like felines, eyes blind and set close to their temples. She didn't remember the name that the doctors, somewhat confused, had given that birth defect. She remembered one of them had called it "mutation."

During that investigation she had met the slum's cleric, Father Francisco, a young parish priest who didn't even wear the white collar. No one came to church, he'd told her. He ran a soup kitchen for the children of the poorest families and he helped where he could, but he'd given up on any kind of pastoral work. There weren't many faithful left, just a few old women. Most of the slum's inhabitants were devotees of Afro-Brazilian cults, or they had adopted their own doctrines, worshipping personal saints like George or Expeditus, setting up shrines to them on corners. "It's not bad," he said, but he didn't say mass anymore except when that handful of old women asked him to. It had seemed to Marina that, behind the smile, the beard, and the long hair—his look of a militant revolutionary from the seventies—the young and well-meaning priest was tired, burdened with a dark desperation.

When the cop left and slammed the door behind him, the DA's secretary waited a few minutes before knocking on the door and announcing that someone else was waiting to see her.

"Not today, hon," said Pinat. She'd been left exhausted and furious, as always when she had to talk with cops.

The secretary shook his head and his eyes implored her.

"Please, Marina, see her. You don't know . . . "

"OK, OK. But this is the last one."

The secretary nodded and thanked her with a look. Marina was already thinking about what to make for dinner that night, or if she felt like going out to a restaurant. Her car was at the mechanic's but she could use the bike; the nights were cool and beautiful that time of year. She wanted to get out of the office, invite a friend out for a beer. She wanted that day to be over and the investigation too, and for the boy's body to finally turn up once and for all.

While she was putting her keys, cigarettes, and some papers into her purse so she could leave quickly, a pregnant teenager came into her office; she was horribly skinny and didn't want to give her name. Marina took a Coca-Cola from the small refrigerator she had under her desk and told her, "I'm listening."

"Emanuel is in Villa Moreno," said the girl between long gulps of soda.

"How far along are you?" Marina asked, indicating the girl's belly.

"I dunno."

Of course she didn't know. Marina calculated the pregnancy was some six months along. The girl's fingertips were burned, stained with the chemical yellow of the crack pipe. The baby, if it was born alive, would be sick, deformed, or addicted.

"How do you know Emanuel?"

"We all know him. Everyone in Moreno knows his family. I went to his funeral. Emanuel used to be kind of my sister's boyfriend."

"And your sister, where is she? Did she recognize him too?"

"No, my sister doesn't live there anymore."

"I'll see. Go on."

"People say Emanuel came out of the water."

"The night they threw him in?"

"No. That's why I'm here. He came out a couple of weeks ago. He's only been back a little while."

Marina felt a shiver. The girl had an addict's dilated pupils, and in the half-light of the office, her eyes looked completely black, like a carrion insect's.

"What do you mean he came back? Did he go somewhere?"

The girl looked at her like she was stupid and her voice became thicker as she held back laughter.

"No! He didn't *go* anywhere. He came back from the water. He was in the water the whole time."

"You're lying."

"No. I came to tell you because you need to know. Emanuel wants to meet you."

She tried not to focus on the way the girl was moving her fingers, stained from the toxic pipe, interweaving them as if they didn't have joints or were extraordinarily soft. Could she be one of the deformed children, the ones with birth defects from the polluted water? No, she was too old. But when had the mutations started? Anything was possible.

"And where is Emanuel now?"

"He's holed up in one of the houses back behind the tracks. He lives there with his friends. Are you going to give me money now? They told me you'd give me money."

Marina kept her in the office a while longer, but she couldn't get much more out of the girl. Emanuel López had come out of the Riachuelo, she said. People had seen him walking through the slum's labyrinthine alleys, and some of them had run away, scared to death when their paths crossed his. They said he walked slowly, and he stank. His mother hadn't wanted to take him in. That part surprised Marina. And he'd gone into one of the vacant houses at the far end of Villa Moreno, past the abandoned train tracks. The girl yanked the bill from Marina's hands when she finally paid her for her testimony. The DA had found her greed reassuring. She thought the girl was lying. Surely some cop friend of the murderers had sent her—or they'd sent her themselves; they were only on house arrest and they certainly didn't comply with it. If one of the boys turned out to be alive, the whole case could collapse. The accused cops had told a lot of their colleagues about how they tortured young thieves by making them "swim" in the Riachuelo. Some of those colleagues had talked, after months of negotiation and outlays of large sums of money to pay for the information. The crime was corroborated, but a dead man who turned out to be alive was one crime less, and it would cast a shadow of doubt over the entire investigation.

That night, Marina was uneasy when she went back to her apartment after a quick and not very stimulating dinner at a new restaurant that had good reviews but terrible service. Her common sense told her that the pregnant girl was only after money, but there was something in her story that sounded strangely real, like a living nightmare. She slept badly, thinking of the dead-but-alive boy's hand touching the shore, the ghost swimmer who returned months after he was murdered. She dreamed that when the boy emerged from the water and shook off the muck, the fingers fell off his hands. She woke up smelling the stench of dead meat, consumed with a horrible fear of finding those swollen, infected fingers between her sheets.

She waited until dawn to try to call someone in Moreno: Emanuel's mother, or Father Francisco. No answer. That wasn't strange; cell phone reception was poor in the city and even worse in the slum. She got alarmed when no one answered the phone in the priest's soup kitchen or in the first-aid clinic. Now that was odd: those places had landlines. Could they have gone out in the last storm?

She kept trying to get in touch with someone all day, unsuccessfully. She canceled everything that afternoon—she told her secretary that her head hurt and she was going to spend the time reading files, and he, ever obedient, had suspended all of her meetings and hearings. That night, as she cooked spaghetti for dinner, she decided that the very next day she would go to Villa Moreno.

NOT MUCH HAD CHANGED since her last time on that southern edge of the city, on the desolate street that led to Moreno Bridge. Out there, Buenos Aires gradually frayed into abandoned storefronts, house windows bricked up to keep squatters out, rusted signs crowning buildings from the seventies. There were still some clothing stores, sketchy butcher shops, and the church, which she remembered being shuttered and still was, she saw now from the taxi; there was, though, a new chain on the door for extra security. This street, she knew, was the dead zone, the emptiest place in the neighborhood. Beyond those run-down façades, which served as a warning, lived the city's poor. Along both of the Riachuelo's banks, thousands of people had used the empty land to build their houses, which ranged from precarious tin shacks to quite decent brick-and-cement apartment buildings. From the bridge you could see the extent of the slum; it stretched out along the black, calm river, fading from sight where there was a bend in the water and it disappeared into the distance among the smokestacks of abandoned factories. People had been talking for years about cleaning up the Riachuelo, that branch of the Rio de la Plata that wended into the city and then moved off southward. For a century it had been the chosen site for dumping all kinds of waste, but especially the offal from cows. Every time Marina got close to the Riachuelo she remembered the stories she'd heard from her father, who for a very short time had been a laborer on the river barges. He told of how they'd dumped everything overboard: the scraps of meat and bone, the muck the animals brought from the country, the shit, the gummed-up grass. "The water turned red," he said. "People were afraid of it."

He also explained to her that the Riachuelo's deep and rotten stench, which with the right wind and the city's constant humidity could hang in the air for days, was caused by the lack of oxygen in the water. Anoxia, he'd told her. "The organic material consumes the oxygen in the liquid," he said with his pompous chemistry teacher's gestures. She'd never understood the formulas, which her father found simple and thrilling, but she never forgot that the black river along the city's edge was

The fact that the crowded hovels of Villa Moreno had been built along the banks of that river depressed Marina. Only truly desperate people went to live there, beside that dangerous and deliberate putrescence.

"This is as far as I go, ma'am."

The driver's voice startled her.

"Where I'm going is three hundred meters farther on," she answered, distant and dry, the tone of voice she used to address lawyers and police officers.

The man shook his head no and turned the car's motor off.

"You can't force me to go into the Villa. I'm asking you to get out here. Are you going in alone?"

The driver sounded frightened, genuinely frightened. She told him yes. Certainly, she'd tried to convince the dead boys' lawyer to come with her, but he had plans he couldn't change. "You're crazy, Marina," he'd told her. "I'll go with you tomor-

row, but today I can't." But she'd been single-minded. And what was she worried about, after all? She'd gone to Moreno several times before. It was the middle of the day. A lot of people knew her; no one would touch her.

She threatened to complain about the driver's behavior to the owners of the taxi service; what a scandal to leave a judiciary official on foot in that area. She couldn't move the man an inch, which was the reaction she expected. No one went near the slum around Moreno Bridge unless it was unavoidable. It was a dangerous place. She herself had left behind her little tailored suits she always wore in the office and in court, opting instead for jeans, a dark shirt, and nothing in her pockets except money to get home and her telephone, both so she could communicate with her contacts in the Villa and so she'd have something valuable to hand over if she was mugged. And of course her gun, which she had a license to use, was discreetly hidden under her shirt. Not so hidden, though, that the outline of its butt and barrel couldn't be seen on her back.

She could enter the Villa by walking down the embankment to the left of the bridge alongside an abandoned building that, strangely, no one had decided to occupy. It was rotting away, corroded by damp, sporting ancient signs advertising massages, tarot readings, accountants, loans. But first she decided to go up onto the bridge; she wanted to see and touch the last place Emanuel and Yamil had seen before they were murdered by police.

The cement stairs were dirty and reeked of urine and rotten food, but she headed up them at a trot. At forty years old, Marina Pinat was in good shape; she went jogging every morning and the court employees whispered that she was "well-preserved" for her age. She detested those murmurings; she wasn't flattered, they offended her. She didn't want to be beautiful, she wanted to be strong and razor sharp.

She reached the platform the boys had been thrown from. She looked down at the stagnant black river and couldn't imagine falling from up there toward that still water, couldn't fathom how the drivers of the cars passing intermittently behind her hadn't seen a thing.

SHE LEFT THE BRIDGE and walked down the embankment by the abandoned building. As soon as she set foot on the street that led into the Villa, she was disconcerted by the silence. It was terribly quiet. That silence was impossible. The neighborhood—any slum, even this one, where only the most idealistic or naïve social workers dared to tread, even in this dangerous and shunned place—should have been full of varied and pleasant sounds. That was how it always was. The different rhythms of music mixing together; the slow, sensual *cumbia villera*; that shrill mix of reggae with a Caribbean beat; the always-present *cumbia santafesina*, with its romantic and sometimes violent lyrics; the motorcycles with their exhaust pipes cut, roaring as

Father Francisco didn't answer. Nor did Emanuel's mother. She thought she could find the small church without a guide; she remembered the way. It was near the entrance to the Villa, like most parish churches. In the short walk there she was surprised at the utter absence of shrines to popular saints—the Gauchito Gils, the Yemojas, even some virgins who usually had a few offerings. She recognized a small yellow-painted house on one of the villa's corners and was comforted to know she wasn't lost. But before she turned that corner, she heard faint steps that squelched—someone was running behind her. She turned around. It was one of the deformed children. She realized it immediately—how could she not? Over time, the face that was ugly on babies had become more horrible: the very wide nose, like a cat's, the eyes wide apart, close to the temples. He opened his mouth, perhaps to call her; he had no teeth.

His body was eight or ten years old, and he didn't have a single tooth.

The boy came up to her, and when he was beside her she could see how the rest of his defects had developed; the fingers had suckers and were thin like squid tails (or were they legs? She never knew what to call them). The boy didn't stop when he reached her. He kept walking toward the church as if guiding her.

The church looked deserted. It had always been a modest house, painted white, and the only indication it was a religious building had been the metal cross on the roof. It was still there, but now it was painted yellow, and someone had decorated it with a crown of yellow and white flowers; from afar they looked like daisies. But the walls of the church were no longer clean. They were covered in graffiti. From up close Marina could see that they were letters, but they didn't form words: YAINGNGAHYOGSOTHOTHHEELGEBFAITHRODOG. The order of the letters, she noticed, was always the same, but it still made no sense to her. The deformed boy opened the church door; Marina shifted her gun to her side and went in.

The building was no longer a church. It had never had wooden pews or a formal altar, just chairs facing a table where Father Francisco gave his sporadic masses. But now it was completely empty, the walls covered in graffiti that copied the letters outside: YAINGNGAHYOGSOTHOTHHEELGEBFAITHRODOG. The crucifix had disappeared, as had the images of the sacred heart of Jesus and Our Lady of Luján.

In place of the altar there was a wooden pole stuck into a common metal flowerpot. And impaled on the pole was a cow's head. The idol—because that's what it was, Marina realized—had to have been recently made, because there was no smell of rotting meat in the church. The head was fresh.

"You shouldn't have come," she heard the priest say. He had entered the building behind her. When she saw him she was even more convinced that something was horribly wrong. The priest was emaciated and dirty, his beard was overgrown and his hair was so greasy it looked wet. But the most startling thing was that he was drunk, and the stench of alcohol oozed from his

pores. When he came into the church it was as if he'd poured a bottle of whiskey over the filthy floor.

"You shouldn't have come," he repeated, and then he slipped. Marina noticed the trailed drops of fresh blood that led from the door to the cow's head.

"What is this, Francisco?"

It took the priest a while to answer. But the deformed child, who had stayed in a corner of what had once been the church, said:

"In his house, the dead man waits dreaming."

"That's all these stupid shits know how to say!" the priest cried, and Marina, who had reached out her arm to help him up from the floor, recoiled. "Filthy, defiled retards! So they sent that *whore* they got *pregnant* to talk to you, and that was all it took to get you to come? I didn't think you were that stupid."

In the distance, Marina heard drums. The *murga,* she thought, relieved. It was February. Of course. That was it. The people had gone to practice the *murga* for carnival, or maybe they were already celebrating in the soccer field over by the train tracks.

"He's holed up in one of the houses back behind the tracks. He lives there, with his friends." *But how did the priest know about the pregnant girl?*

It was the *murga*, she was sure. The Villa had a traditional troupe and they always celebrated carnival. It was a little early, but it was possible. And the cow's head must be a gift from one of the neighborhood drug dealers, meant to intimidate. They hated Father Francisco because he reported them to the police or tried to rehabilitate the addicted kids, which meant taking away their customers and employees.

"You have to get out of here, Francisco," she told him.

The priest laughed.

"I tried, I tried! But there's no getting out. You're not going to get out either. That boy woke up the thing sleeping under the water. Don't you hear them? The cult of the dead? Don't you hear the drums?"

"It's carnival."

"Carnival? Does that sound like carnival to you?"

"You're drunk. How did you know about the pregnant girl?"

"That's no carnival."

The priest stood up and tried to light a cigarette.

"You know, for years I thought that rotten river was a sign of our ineptitude. How we never think about the future. Sure, we'll just toss all the muck in here, let the river wash it away! We never think about the consequences. A country full of incompetents. But now I see things differently, Marina. Those people *were* being responsible when they polluted that river. They were covering something up, something they didn't want to let out, and they buried it under layers and layers of oil and mud! They even clogged the river with boats! Just left them there, deadlocked!"

"What are you talking about?"

"Don't play dumb. You were never stupid. The police started throwing people in there because *they* are stupid. And most of the people they threw in died, but some of them found it. Do you know the kind of foulness that reaches us here? The shit from all the houses, all the filth from the sewers, everything! Layers and layers of filth to keep it dead or asleep. It's the same thing, I believe sleep and death are the same thing. And it worked, until people started to do the unthinkable: they swam under the black water. And they woke the thing up. Do you know what *Emanuel* means? It means 'God is with us.' The problem is, what God are we talking about?"

"You're talking bullshit, that's the problem. Let's go, I'm getting you out of here."

The priest started to rub his eyes so hard Marina was afraid he would tear his corneas. The blind, deformed child had turned around and now had his back to them, his forehead against the wall.

"They set him on me to guard me. He's their son."

Marina tried to piece together what was really happening: the priest, hounded by those who hated him in the Villa, had gone crazy. The deformed child, who'd surely been abandoned by his family, followed him everywhere because he had no one else. The neighborhood people had taken their music and their barbecues to the carnival festivities. It was all frightening, but it wasn't impossible. There was no dead boy walking around, there was no death cult.

But why were there no religious images? And why had the priest talked about Emanuel when she hadn't even asked?

It doesn't matter, we're leaving, thought Marina, and she grabbed the priest's arm so he could lean on her to walk, since he was too drunk to do it alone. That was a mistake. She had no time to react; the priest was drunk, but his movement when he grabbed her gun was surprisingly fast and precise. She couldn't even fight back, nor did she see that the deformed child had turned around and started screaming mutely. His mouth was open and he screamed without a sound.

The priest pointed the gun at her. She looked around, her heart pummeling her ribs, her mouth dry. She couldn't escape; he was drunk, he might miss, but it wasn't likely in such a small space. She started to plead, but he interrupted her.

"I don't want to kill you. I want to thank you."

And then he wasn't pointing the gun at her. He lowered it and then quickly raised it again, put it in his mouth, and fired.

The shot left Marina deaf. The priest's brains now covered part of the nonsense letters, and the boy repeated: "In his house, the dead man waits dreaming." He had trouble with the *r* sound, though, and he pronounced it "dweaming." Marina didn't try to help the priest; there was no chance he'd survived the shot. She took the gun from his hand and couldn't help thinking that her prints were everywhere, that she could be accused of killing him. Shitty priest, shitty slum, why was she even there? To prove what, and to whom? The gun was trembling in her hand, now covered in blood. She didn't know how she was going to go home with her hands all bloodied. She had to find clean water.

When she emerged from the church she realized she was crying, and that the Villa wasn't empty anymore. Her deafness

after the gunshot had made her think the drums were still far away, but she was wrong. The *murga* was passing right in front of the church. Only it was clear now that it wasn't a *murga*. It was a procession. A line of people playing the same loud snare drums as in the *murga*, led by deformed children with their skinny arms and mollusk fingers, followed by women, most of them fat, their bodies disfigured by a diet based on carbs. There were some men, just a few, and Marina recognized among them some policemen she knew; she even thought she recognized Súarez, with his dark hair slicked back and wearing his uniform, violating his house arrest.

After them came the idol, which they were carrying on a bed. That was what it was: a bed, complete with a mattress. Marina couldn't see the figure clearly; it was lying down. It was human-sized. She had once seen something similar during Holy Week, effigies of Jesus just taken down from the cross, blood on white cloth, something between a bed and a coffin.

She moved closer to the procession, though everything told her she should run in the opposite direction. She wanted to see what was lying on the bed.

The dead man waits dreaming.

Among the people walking quietly, the only sound came from the drums. She tried to move closer to the idol, craning her neck, but the bed was very high, inexplicably high. A woman pushed her when she tried to get too close and Marina recognized her; it was Emanuel's mother. She tried to stop her but the woman murmured something about the barges and the dark depths of the water, where the house was, and she pushed Marina away from her with a head butt right when the people in the procession began to shout "yo, yo, yo," and the thing they were carrying on the bed moved a little, enough for one of its gray arms to fall over the side of the bed. It was like the arm of a very sick person, and Marina remembered the fingers in her dream, the fingers falling from the rotten hand, and only then did she start running away with her gun drawn. While she ran she prayed in a low voice like she hadn't done since she was a child. She ran between the precarious houses, through labyrinthine alleys, searching for the embankment, the shore, trying to ignore the fact that the black water seemed agitated, because it couldn't be, because that water didn't breathe, the water was dead, it couldn't kiss the banks with waves, it couldn't be ruffled by the wind, it couldn't have those eddies or the current or that swelling, how could there be a swelling when the water was stagnant? Marina ran toward the bridge and didn't look back and she covered her ears with her bloody hands to block out the noise of the drums.

IT HAPPENED one night. I was living in the boardinghouse in Córdoba. I had finished my classes at the university, and was walking down a deserted street. A car pulled up next to me and the driver asked me what I was doing. "Going home from university," I answered, but he didn't believe me. Then he cut to the chase and asked me how much I charged. I ventured a number, which he agreed to. It was quick and unremarkable. I can't even remember his face or body. It doesn't merit chronicling. When I went to bed that night I didn't feel a thing, not guilt or pleasure or anger. Nothing. The person who went to sleep that night was half what I am today. The other half was being swallowed up by the fate that had always awaited: to become a whore. That is how one gets into prostitution. The father has done what the world asks of him: he has asked his faggot son in every way possible not to become a travesti, a big whore. To deny herself life, to make a pact with God and live without living, to be someone different, to be his son but not under any circumstances to be what he wants to be: what he wants all the world to see. But the revelation can't be suppressed. How can you hide what has already begun to manifest itself right from the heart of the stone, what was lurking inside the stone for one's whole life, something to be experienced, not just put on display?

An untraceable reality, impossible to know where it began, when one decided to become a prostitute. But the body adapts. It's like a liquid that can mold itself to any shape you set it. Muscles harden or fatten, armor begins to form. Full body armor. Your eyes grow shields. You can't be a prostitute without numbing yourself completely.

One night, everything suddenly seems easy. It's as simple as that. Your body produces money. You set a price and a length of time. Then you spend the money on whatever you want: you squander it as easily as you earned it. You've taken the reins. You're now in charge of your fate. Each and every one of us made the choice to be a prostitute. Age is irrelevant. It doesn't matter that Maria is a deaf-mute, that Auntie Encarna is 178 years old. It doesn't matter if you're a minor, if you're illiterate, if you have a family. The only thing that matters is the shop window. The world is a shop window. We prostitute ourselves to make payments on everything we see in those windows.

Just one night and that's it. One night and the money is in our hands, in our purses. The next day, we pay the rent, tamp down the flirting. One night and we can be like them, the prodigal daughters who go shopping, pay off debts, pound feel for us. It must be forbidden as an eternal punishment, for disobeying the rules. To punish us they say no one will want us. But life couldn't go on without us there, outside of everything. The economy would collapse, every norm and stricture would be burned up in the savagery of existence if we whores weren't there to offer our bodily love. Without prostitutes, this world would founder in the darkness of the universe.

There are cockerels around here somewhere.

Kneeling, with my head down and covered by a filthy rag, I concentrate on hearing them: how many there are, if they're in cages or inside a pen. When I was young, my dad raised gamecocks, and since there wasn't anyone else to look after me, he'd take me along to the fights. The first few times, I cried when I saw the poor cockerel ripped to shreds in the sand, and he laughed and called me a girl.

At night, giant vampire cockerels devoured my insides. I would scream and he'd come running to my bed, and again he'd call me a girl.

'Come on, don't be such a girl. They're just cockerels, dammit.'

Eventually I stopped crying when I saw the hot guts of the losing cockerel in the dust. I was the one who had to clean up the ball of feathers and viscera and carry it all to the rubbish bin. I would say: 'Bye-bye, cockerel. Be happy in heaven where there are thousands of worms and fields and corn and families that love cockerels.' On the way, some cockfighter would give me a sweet or a coin to touch me or kiss me, or for me to touch him or kiss him. I was afraid that if I told Dad, he'd call me a girl again.

'Come on, don't be such a girl. They're just cockfighters, dammit.'

One night, a cockerel's belly exploded as I was carrying it in my arms like a doll, and I discovered that those macho men who shouted and jeered for one cockerel to rip open the other were disgusted by the shit and blood and guts of the dead cockerel. So I covered my hands, my knees, and my face with that mixture, and they didn't bother me with kisses and all that bullshit anymore.

They said to my dad, 'Your daughter is a monster.'

And he responded that they were the monsters and they clinked their shot glasses.

'You guys are the monsters. Salud.'

The smell inside the cockpit was disgusting. Sometimes when I fell asleep in a corner, under the stands, I'd wake up with one of those men peeking underneath my school uniform at my underwear. So before falling asleep I would stick a cockerel head between my legs. One, sometimes more. A whole belt of cockerel heads. Those macho guys didn't like lifting up a skirt to find little severed heads.

Sometimes, Dad would wake me up to clear away a gutted cockerel. Sometimes, he did the cleaning himself, and his friends called him a faggot, asked him why the hell he even bothered to bring his daughter. He just gathered up the ruined and bloody cockerel. Then from the door he blew them a kiss. His friends laughed.

I know that here, somewhere, there are cockerels because I'd recognise that smell from a thousand miles away. The smell of my life, the smell of my father. It smells of blood, of man, of shit, of cheap liquor, of sour sweat and industrial grease. You don't exactly have to be a genius to gather that this is some abandoned place, hidden away god knows where, and that I'm totally fucked.

A man speaks. He must be around forty. I imagine him fat, bald, and dirty, wearing a sleeveless white undershirt, shorts, and flip-flops; I imagine his pinkie and thumb nails are long. I can tell by the way he's speaking that there are other people here. There's someone else here besides me. There are other people on their knees, with their heads bent, covered by dark, disgusting sacks.

'Come on now, let's all calm down – the first *sonofabitch* who makes a sound is gonna get a bullet in his head. If you all cooperate, we'll all make it through the night in one piece.'

I feel his stomach brush against my head and then the barrel of a gun. No, he's not joking.

A girl cries a few feet to my right. I suppose she couldn't handle the feeling of the gun to her temple. The sound of a slap.

'Look, princess. No crying, you hear me? Or are you in a big hurry to meet your maker?'

Later, the fat man with the gun walks away. He's gone to talk on the phone. He says a number: 'Six, six motherfuckers.' He also says, 'It's a good haul, really good, the best in months.' He says they won't want to miss it. He makes one call after another. He forgets, for a while, about us.

Beside me I hear a cough muffled by a hood, a man's cough.

'I've heard about this,' he says, very softly. 'I thought it was a myth, an urban legend. They're called auctions. Taxi drivers choose passengers they think they'll be able to get good money for and they kidnap them. Then buyers come and bid on their favourites. And they take them. They keep their things, they force them to steal, to open up their houses, to give them their credit card numbers. And the women . . . the women.'

'What?' I ask.

He hears that I'm a woman. He goes quiet.

The first thing I thought when I got in the taxi that night was *finally*. I rested my head on the seat and closed my eyes. I'd had several drinks and I was depressed. I'd been at the bar with a man I pretended to be friends with. With him and his wife. I always pretend, I'm good at pretending. But when I got in the taxi, I sighed and said to myself, 'What a relief: now I can go home and cry myself to sleep.' I think I dozed off for a minute, and suddenly, when I opened my eyes, I was in an unfamiliar place. An industrial area. Empty. Darkness. Mind-numbing fear: someone was about to fuck up my life forever.

The taxi driver pulled out a gun, looked me in the eye, and said with absurd politeness: 'We've reached your destination, miss.'

What followed was quick. Someone opened the door

before I could lock it and put a sack over my head, they tied my hands, shoved me into this sort of garage that smelled like a rotting cockpit, and made me kneel in a corner.

The sound of conversations. The fat man and someone else and then someone else and someone else. People keep coming. The sound of laughter and beers being opened. The scent of weed and some other shit with a spicy smell. The man next to me finally stops telling me to keep calm. He must be saying it to himself now.

He mentioned before that he has an eight-month-old baby and a three-year-old son. He must be thinking about them. And about these junkies getting inside the gated community where they live. That must be what he's thinking about. About waving to the guard to open the gate while these beasts duck down in the back seat. He's going to take them home to meet his beautiful wife, his eight-month-old baby, and his three-year-old son. He's going to take them to his house.

And there's nothing he can do about it.

Further away, to the right, murmuring, a girl cries, I don't know if it's the same one who was crying before. The fat man fires his gun and we all drop to the floor. He hasn't shot us, he's just shot. It doesn't matter, the terror has ripped us in half. He and his friends laugh. They come over, they move us into the centre of the room.

'All right, gentlemen, ladies, tonight's auction is officially open. They're all so lovely, so well-behaved. Now, you stand here for me. Closer, princess. Riiiiight there. Don't be afraid, little lady, I don't bite. Just like that. So these gentlemen can decide which one of you they're going to take. The rules are the same as always, gentlemen: the most money gets the best prize. If you could leave your guns over here for me, I'll keep them safe till the auction's over. Thank you. Delighted, as always, to have you.'

The fat man presents us like he's hosting a TV show. We can't see the audience, but we know the men who are looking at us, sizing us up, are thieves. And rapists. They are definitely rapists. And murderers. They might be murderers. Or something worse.

'Laaaaaaadies and geeeeeeeentlemen!'

The fat man doesn't like the ones who whimper or the ones who say they have kids or the ones who shout desperately, 'You don't know who you're messing with!' No. He likes even less the ones who say he's going to rot in jail. All these people, men and women alike, have been punched in the gut. I've heard them fall to the floor breathless. I focus on the cockerels. Maybe there aren't any. But I hear them. Inside me. Men and cockerels. *Come on, don't be such a girl. They're just cockfighters, dammit.*

'This man, what's our first participant's name? What? Speak up, friend. Ricardoooooo, welcoooome. He wears a nice watch and some niiiiiice Adidas shoes. Ricardooooo must have moneyyyyyyyy! Let's take a look at Ricardo's wallet. Credit cards, ohhhhhh a Visa *Goooaaald* by Messi.'

The fat man tells bad jokes.

They start to bid on Ricardo. Someone offers three hundred, another person eight hundred. The fat man adds that Ricardo lives in a gated community outside the city: Riverview.

'A view poor folks like us can't even get a glimpse of. That's where our friend Richie lives. You don't mind if we call you Richie, do you? Like Richie Rich.'

A terrifying voice says five thousand. The terrifying voice takes Ricardo away. The others applaud.

'Sold to the man with the moustache for five thousand!'

The fat man fondles Nancy, a girl who speaks with a thread of a voice. I know he's groping her because he says, 'Look at these delicious tits, such perky nipples,' and he sucks up his drool and says things you don't say without touching and, also, who's to stop him from touching her? No one. Nancy sounds young. Early twenties. She could be a nurse or a schoolteacher. The fat man starts to undress Nancy. We hear him unbuckle her belt and unbutton her jeans and rip her underwear while she says *please* so many times and with such fear in her voice that we all stain our filthy hoods with tears. 'Look at this fine little ass. What a beauty.' He licks Nancy, Nancy's ass. We hear the sound. The men jeer, roar, applaud. Then the slap of flesh against flesh. And the howls. The howls.

'Gentlemen, just some quality control for you. I give her a ten. You can clean her up real pretty and our friend Nancy will be a delight.'

She must be beautiful because they bid, immediately, two thousand, three thousand, three thousand five. Nancy goes for three thousand five. Sexy goes for less than wealthy.

'And the lucky man taking this lovely piece of ass home is the gentleman with the gold ring and the cross!'

We're sold off one by one. The fat man manages to get a lot of information out of the guy next to me, the one with the eight-month-old baby and the three-year-old son, and now he's the auction's prized pig: money in different accounts, high-up executive, son of a businessman, art collector, kids, wife. The guy is a winning lottery ticket. They'll probably ask a ransom for him. The bid starts at five thousand. It goes up to ten, fifteen. It stops at twenty. Someone intimidating has offered twenty thousand. A new voice. He's come just for this. He wasn't interested in wasting his time on anyone else.

The fat man doesn't make any jokes.

When it's my turn I think about the cockerels. I close my eyes and open my sphincter. I know that this is the most important thing I will do in my life, so I do it right. I soak my legs, my feet, the floor. I'm in the centre of a room, surrounded by criminals, displayed before them like cattle, and like cattle I empty my bowels. As best I can, I rub one leg against the other, I assume the position of a gutted doll. I scream like a madwoman. I shake my head, mutter obscenities, gibberish, the things I used to say to the cockerels about a heaven filled with endless corn and worms. I know the fat man is about

to shoot me.

But instead, he busts my lip open with his hand. I bite my tongue. The blood drips onto my chest, down my belly, mixes with the shit and piss. I start to laugh, deranged, to laugh, and laugh, and laugh.

He doesn't know what to do.

'How much for this monster?'

No one wants to bid.

The fat man offers up my watch, my cell phone, my purse. They're all cheap, made in China. He grabs my tits in an attempt to encourage them and I shriek.

'Fifteen, twenty?'

But nothing, no one.

They toss me outside. They hose me down and then they put me in a car that leaves me wet, barefoot, dazed, on the side of the highway.

Especially if he happens to be topless. He has a colossal gut scored with fat, raised knife scars that look like faded stretchmarks against his dark skin.

His eyes shine with the squinting innocence of grinning Totonac faces; his smile, too, full of sharp little teeth, resembles those stone figures. He shaves his head, not because his bosses make him, but because he hates it when his colleagues laugh at his curls.

'No one's calling *me* Kalimba. I'm El Fito,' he explains proudly, thumping his chest with his hand. His double chin wobbles like jelly.

It was never El Fito's dream to be a narco, even though in his time he's been a burglar, mugger and drug addict. Having spent his teenage years smoking 'rock', his one remaining weakness is weed. Things changed when he found out his wife was pregnant with their daughter.

'Well, I wasn't going to steal bread from the girl's mouth...'

His daughter is a miniature version of him, just as chubby, and with the same dark brown skin. She shows off her semi-professional reggaeton moves to the beat of Oskar Lobo's 'El Za Za Za'. El Fito says he doesn't see an issue with smoking weed in front of her, she's too young to even notice, but he can't hide his shame when, engulfed in a thick cloud of smoke, the girl refuses to go to him and instead buries her crying face in her mother's shawl.

Because El Fito does it all for them. Or that's what he says. A year ago he was out of work and flat broke, living under a roof that was literally falling in on them – in shady social housing contractor who built it. The customs agency where El Fito worked back then let him go when the financial crisis hit; the owners made staff cuts and his lack of education cost him his job.

He did the rounds at agencies all over the city centre: a great, fat, sweaty guy with a thuggish, occasionally even menacing expression and a feeble CV, full of spelling mistakes.

'He's a good asset,' says El Chilango, an ex-colleague of El Fito from the customs agency where he worked before. 'He always worked the red shift. Whenever a red light flashed on down in customs, the boss would send the big man down there; she knew he'd stay on until the goods had been dispatched, as late as three or four in the morning if that's what it took. And she knew the next day he'd be back in the office by eight. And he was only paid about four thousand pesos a month.'

El Chilango lets out a sigh. He swirls the last swig of beer in his bottle as if it were cognac, then knocks it back.

'You couldn't meet a more decent guy, he's got a heart of gold. He'd give you the shirt off his back. Shame he ended up with that lot. We don't know a thing about his life now.'

El Fito joined 'the company' thanks to an old friend from the north. They bumped into each other on the street one day and arranged to meet up and reminisce about old times. A few days later they were smoking joints and eating in the famous torta bar 'El Gallo'. The friend confessed that he worked for Los Zetas; and after he'd heard about the run of bad luck El Fito was having, he encouraged him to join and get in on the action.

El Fito was called for an interview the very next day. There were three candidates. The boss hit them all with the butt of his gun and threatened to kill them if they chickened out.

'No one backs out, do you hear? You're here to work, motherfuckers!' bellowed the boss, who ran the cartel's area of operations, or 'plaza' and himself had only recently broken out of jail in Saltillo: none other than Ezequiel Cárdenas Guillén, better known as Tony Tormenta.

But El Fito didn't back out. He endured fifteen days of incarceration as part of his 'initiation' and was hired as an assembly worker for two thousand five hundred pesos a week, plus a 'loyalty bonus'. He would work two or three days straight, or sometimes for an entire week in a residential complex on the outskirts of town, inside a run-down, seemingly abandoned house owned by 'the company'. There, they would sit El Fito down at a table where he'd use of his dexterous hands – his fingers nimble from a lifetime of rolling joints – to scrape away at the brick of cocaine in front of him and prepare small two-gram bags that would later be sold at 24-hour convenience stores.

Once his batch was completed, El Fito could sit back and relax, or even sleep or play PlayStation with the other assembly workers – none of them had to worry about anything but their own production. There was even a woman who came to clean the place, and another who cooked their meals.

The worst days were when they did 'quality control' and the boss would show up with his goons and an expert to check the quality of the 'merchandise' with reagents and scales. Pity the worker whose batch was short by a single gram: that thief would have his ass whipped with a sixty-centimetre wooden cane, which was passed from goon to goon so no one got too tired. The offender never relapsed, because on the second offence, he would either be disappeared or bumped off, which amounted to the same thing.

Now El Fito can afford to buy himself a pair of new trainers every fortnight. He's a good asset, born under a lucky star, his bosses tell him; they've moved him up to another 'department' of 'the company' now. These days he travels a lot; sometimes whole weeks go by without his wife knowing where he is. He's fixed the roof of his house, and

he no longer struggles to make ends meet, even if he can't see his family whenever he wants anymore, even if he does bear the cross of knowing that at any moment something terrible could happen to them.

Every now and then he allows himself the luxury of sending an SMS to his old buddies like El Chilango. He no longer goes into detail about what he does, and he always tells them to erase his number from their phones, but at least this way his friends know that El Fito's still alive, that his head's still where it should be, not on a coroner's table or rotting among the weeds in an abandoned lot somewhere.

Maravilloso Reading Group was
conceived by Ros del Olmo and Ire

Organisational support by argos
centre for audiovisual arts

quote on cover by Sayak Valencia

10/08/2025
Brussels